

PANEL DISCUSSION

How Is Psychotherapy Evolving?

Moderator: Ms. Dhanisha V.P.

Panelists: Mr. Jayakrishnan K. • Dr. Naseem Vakkath • Ms. Arshina Asainar

Brief Summary

This discussion on the evolution of psychotherapy highlights the role of technology and AI in modern therapy. The panelists opined that therapists are catalysts for transformation in clients beyond just providing information, and that one can only survive in this field through continuous learning and skill development.

Detailed Summary

Introduction

This session was organized on the topic 'How is Psychotherapy Evolving?'. Moderated by Ms. Dhanisha V.P., co-founder of Manoyathra, the panel discussion featured prominent psychotherapist and trainer Mr. Jayakrishnan K., Remindful Managing Director Ms. Arshina Asainar, and Consultant Psychiatrist Dr. Naseem Vakkath. The session served as a platform for academic discussions on new changes in the mental health field, the influence of technology, and the use of AI.

Main Theme: The Evolution and Future Possibilities of Psychotherapy

The focal point of this discussion was how therapy is shifting from traditional methods toward modern neuroscience and technology. The panelists emphasized that therapists are not merely providers of information, but catalysts for transformation in their clients' lives.

Key Areas Explored

Skill Development for Therapists

The panelists pointed out that a degree alone is not enough to succeed as a therapist. Beyond clinical knowledge, 'inside skills' necessary to attract and retain clients are essential. Empathy is not just a word, but the ability to think from the client's perspective. Furthermore, every therapist needs to find their 'niche'. It is essential to stay updated on new therapeutic methods in psychology, such as DBT (Dialectical Behavior Therapy) and ACT (Acceptance and Commitment Therapy).

Will AI Revolutionize Therapy?

The panelists addressed concerns about whether AI tools like ChatGPT would replace therapists. They noted that AI provides information, but the therapist provides transformation. AI has limitations in understanding non-verbal language, human complexity, and cultural sensitivity. AI can be used as an assistant, but it can never replace a therapist.

Online vs. Offline Therapy

Studies suggest that online and offline therapy are equally effective. However, Dr. Naseem Vakkath opined that a hybrid model is the most effective. Using an offline approach for initial assessment and an online approach for follow-up sessions is convenient for clients.

Key Insights

- 1. Continuous Learning:** Psychology is an evolving field. Continuing education after graduation is essential for a therapist's survival.
- 2. Diagnostic Formulation:** Instead of just taking a history, the ability to summarize a client's problems in 10-15 lines elevates a therapist's standard.
- 3. Use of Technology:** Social media and digital platforms should be effectively used for personal branding and raising awareness.

Conclusion

The panelists reminded therapists that they must always stay updated, or they risk becoming obsolete. Encouraging students to develop a growth mindset for their careers, the session concluded with thanks to Sereniche Academy Academy and KMM College.

Social Media Highlights

Continuous learning and updating for therapists

A therapist's education does not end with a psychology degree or PG. Since this field is constantly changing, learning new therapy methods (DBT, ACT, trauma-focused therapy) and keeping oneself updated is essential to retain clients and provide better service.

The relationship between AI and the therapist

AI should be viewed not as a competitor, but as an assistant. While AI can help gather information, it cannot handle the 'transformation' that is a therapist's main goal, nor can it manage human empathy, understanding non-verbal cues, and human complexity.

Expertise in clinical practice

A therapist should not just be a listener, but someone capable of scientifically analyzing a client's problems. Diagnostic formulation, the ability to ask precise questions (questioning skills), and cultural sensitivity elevate a therapist's standard.

Online, offline, and hybrid models

Research indicates that online therapy and offline therapy are equal in effectiveness. However, a 'hybrid' method combining both is seen as the most effective, depending on the client's convenience and needs.